



**HARRIET
MARTINEAU**

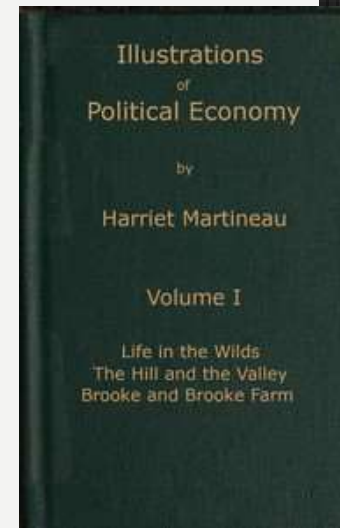
OUTLINE

1. The author and the context
2. How to Observe: On morals and manners (1838)
3. Society in America (1837)
4. Contribution to sociology

1. THE AUTHOR

- UK 1802-1876
- French Huguenot Family, self-taught scholar.
- Prolific author of fiction and journalism.
- Very popular during her life.
- Illustrations of political economy series.
- Translated Comte's "Positive Philosophy"

into English, and adopted some of its principles.

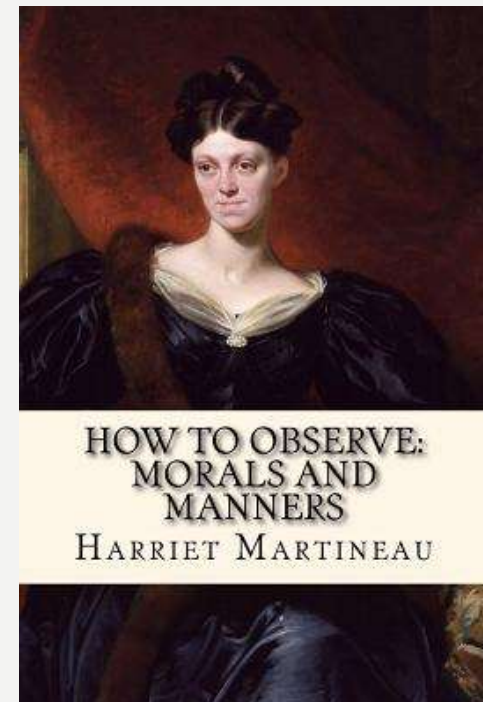


AND THE CONTEXT

- Victorian England. A society that is becoming “modern” but still imbued with traditionalism.
- Accelerated social change.
- Intellectual debates on democracy, equality, poverty, progress and the role of religion and science.
- Interest for travel and historical comparisons. Particular interest for the United States.

2. HOW TO OBSERVE: ON MORALS AND MANNERS (1838)

- A book written in preparation for her research on the United States. A methodological handbook for “[travelers](#)” who want to understand society. Probably the first book on the methodology of social research (Lipset).
- Societal phenomena need to be understood in relation with each other. We need to look at:
 1. Religion
 2. General moral notions
 3. The domestic state
 4. The idea of liberty
 5. Progress
 6. Discourses
- Acknowledging that the traveller is [imperfect](#).



- Traveler=
- Manners=
- Morals=
- Premise: “The grand secret of wise inquiry into morals and manners is to begin with the study of things, using the discourse of persons as a commentary upon them”

The chief reason why the discourse of individuals, apart from the observation of classes of fact, is almost purely deceptive as to morals, is that the traveler can see no more than one in fifty thousand of the people, and has no security that those he meets are a sample of the whole. This difficulty does not interfere with one very important advantage which he may obtain from conversation,—knowledge of and light upon particular questions.

1. Philosophical recommendations for the observer:

- A certainty about what we want to know (a research question)
- Principles to serve as a rallying point (hypotheses)
- A method that will work (method)
- A moral conviction
- Knowledge of general trends

2. Moral requisites (methodological):

- Sympathy to find their way to hearts and minds
- To not allow themselves to be disgusted or perplexed by human behavior
- To think about the dangers of attracting spirits like their [own](#)
- No feelings of [discouragement](#)
- Understanding that we make ourselves better by observing
- Looking for general patterns rather than individual reports

3. Mechanical requisites: a way of transportation, a diary to take notes

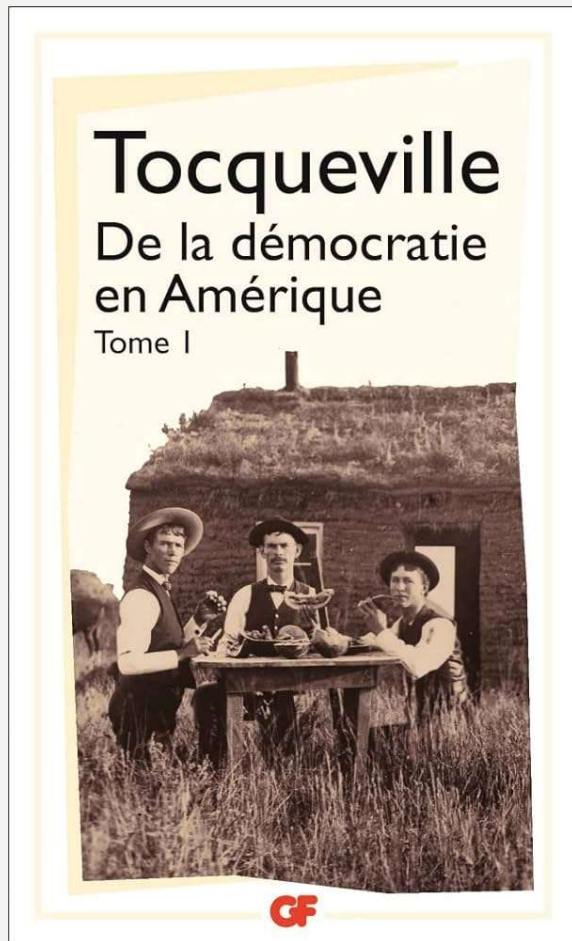
- Specific recommendations
- To stand on the highest pinnacle to obtain a more accurate view

[The traveller] must seek intercourse with all classes of the society he visits,—not only the rich and the poor, but those who may be classed by profession, pursuit, habits of mind, and turn of manners. He must converse with young men and maidens, old men and children, beggars and savants, postillions and potentates. . . .

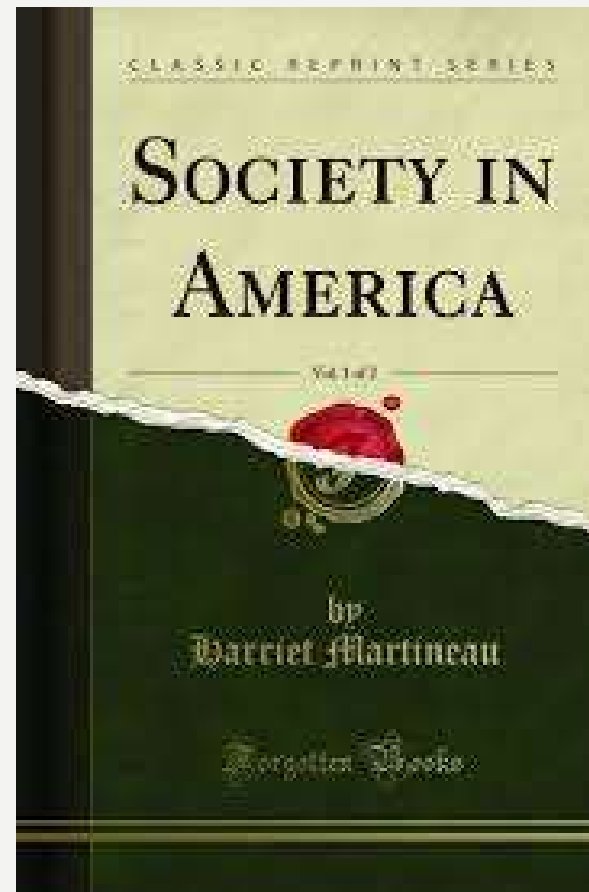
Above all things, the traveler must not despair of good results from his observations. Because he cannot establish true conclusions by imperfect means, he is not to desist from doing anything at all. Because he cannot safely generalize in one way, it does not follow that there is no other way. There are methods of safe generalization of which I shall speak by-and-by. But, if there were not such within his reach, if his only materials were the discourse, the opinions, the feelings, the way of life, the looks, dress, and manners of individuals, he might still afford important contributions to science by his observations on as wide a variety of these as he can bring within his mental grasp. The experience of a large number of observers would in time yield materials from which a cautious philosopher might draw conclusions. It is a safe rule, in morals as in physics, that no fact is without its use. Every observer and recorder is fulfilling a function, and no one observer or recorder ought to feel discouragement, as long as he desires to be useful rather than shining; to be the servant rather than the lord of science, and a friend to the home-stayers rather than their dictator.

3. SOCIETY IN AMERICA

1835-40



1837



- **Aim:** compare the current state of society with the values and principles on which it was found.
 - Assumption about values (Weber, Myrdal).
 - Focus on politics, the economy, social norms, and religion.
- **Methods:** analysis of documents, observations, and interviews during almost two years of fieldwork, in different regions of the United States (1832-34).
- Some interesting results
- Political participation;
 - The risk of majority bias
 - The role of federal government
 - Is political participation higher in the US than in Europe? Tocqueville vs. Martineau

- Social stratification: absence of aristocracy (institutional and ideological reasons) and its consequences on social stratification and individual behavior.
 - Emergence of a pseudo-aristocracy
 - Status-consciousness and conformism
 - Mercenary behaviors
- Observations on religiosity and family life
- Contradictions between the American creed and social phenomena:
 - Slavery
 - Women
 - Migrants

COMPARISON WITH TOCQUEVILLE

- Similar objectives on paper: observing the main social institutions in the USA almost at the same time.
- Similar routes and interviewing key informants.
- Similar but also different backgrounds and objectives.
- Different understandings of democracy (elitist versus inclusive).
- Different methodological approaches and fieldwork.
- Different writing styles.
- And different impact...

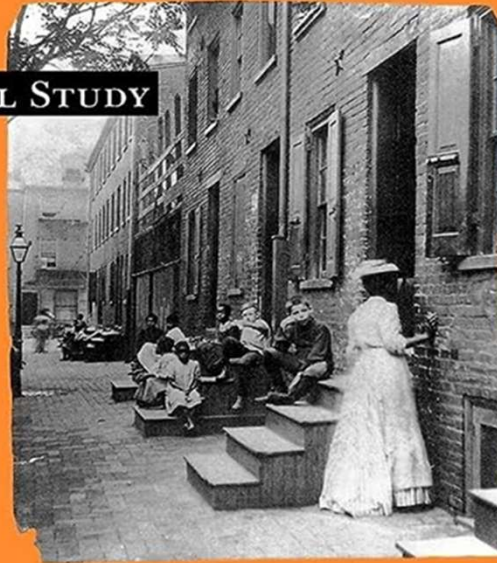
4. CONTRIBUTIONS TO SOCIOLOGY

- Author of the first methodological book for the social sciences
 - Advocates rigorous empirical research
 - Advances questions on sampling, biases in the observer and the samples, generalization, fieldwork.
- Presents an approach to analyse societies that takes into account the embeddedness of social institutions, norms and behaviors, and both micro and macro sociology.
- Contributes to sociological research on religion, suicide, politics, inequalities, among others.
- Despite the popularity of her work during her lifetime, her contribution was not taken into consideration for a long time. Why?

W.E.B. DuBois

The Philadelphia Negro

A SOCIAL STUDY



With a new Introduction by ELIJAH ANDERSON